

Bloomberg Bloomberg

Companies Are Warming Up to Saying AI Is the Reason for Job Cuts

裁员理由不再遮遮掩掩，“AI干的”成官方说法



译文

P1 In late September, the German airline Deutsche Lufthansa AG told analysts and investors that it planned to eliminate 4,000 administrative positions by the end of the decade. Among the reasons it cited was "the increased use of artificial intelligence."

P2 Weeks later, Dutch lender ING Groep NV said nearly 1,000 positions were at risk from "digitalization, AI, and evolving customer needs."

P3 For much of the AI boom, many companies shied away from attributing job cuts to artificial intelligence for fear of attracting negative headlines. But in recent months, large firms across industries and geographic regions have become more vocal with claims that AI is allowing them to eliminate staff and reduce hiring.

P4 In earnings reports, investor presentations and company memos, executives have been touting efficiency gains from artificial intelligence and framing a shrinking or flat workforce as preparation for an increasingly AI-driven economy. AI has been cited for 48,414 job cuts announced in the US so far this year, according to a recent estimate from outplacement firm Challenger, Gray & Christmas. Of those, 31,039 AI-related job cuts were announced in October alone.

P5 In the US, corporations that had been hoarding employees in a "low hire, low fire" labor market are now starting to make cuts as they confront the ongoing economic uncertainties and worsening consumer sentiment. Many big companies, especially in the tech industry, also "overexpanded during the recent boom and ended up with very large labor forces," said George Denlinger, an operational president at staffing agency Robert Half.

9月下旬，德国汉莎航空公司告诉分析师和投资者，该公司计划在本十年结束前裁减4,000个行政职位。它引用的原因之一是“人工智能的使用增加。”

几周后，荷兰银行ING Groep NV表示，近1,000个职位面临“数字化、人工智能和不断变化的客户需求”的风险。”

在人工智能繁荣的大部分时间里，许多公司都避免将裁员归咎于人工智能，因为担心引起负面头条新闻。但近几个月来，各个行业和地理区域的大公司越来越直言不讳地声称人工智能正在使他们能够裁员并减少招聘。

在收益报告、投资者陈述和公司备忘录中，高管们一直在宣扬人工智能带来的效率提高，并将劳动力规模缩小或持平视为为日益人工智能驱动的经济做好准备。根据再就业公司Challenger, Gray & Christmas的最新估计，今年迄今为止，美国已宣布裁员48,414人，人工智能已被提及。其中，仅10月份就宣布裁员31,039人。

在美国，由于面临持续的经济不确定性和消费者情绪恶化，那些一直在“低雇佣、低火”劳动力市场囤积员工的企业现在开始裁员。人力资源机构Robert Half的运营总裁乔治·丹林格（George Denlinger）表示，许多大公司，尤其是科技行业的大公司，也“在最近的繁荣中过度扩张，最终拥有了非常庞大的劳动力”。

P6 For that reason, the emphasis on AI can sometimes be misleading.

P7 The muddled motivations can be seen at large tech firms like Amazon. In June, the e-commerce giant's chief executive officer, Andy Jassy, signaled that the company's workforce would decline in the coming years as AI handles more tasks. Four months later, Amazon announced it would cut 14,000 jobs, a move that Jassy said is "not even really AI driven, not right now." Instead, he chalked it up to having a more bloated bureaucracy.

P8 But the recent spate of announcements about AI-related cutbacks does offer some hints of sweeping job displacement that critics of the technology — and even its evangelists — have long warned about. Over the past year, AI has progressed from chatbots that spit out clever responses to so-called agents designed to field more complex tasks on a user's behalf, whether it be conducting research or writing code for hours at a time.

P9 "AI is starting to eat repetitive, high-volume work," said Mike Doonan of SPMB, which recruits senior tech and data leaders. One large client, he said, laid off its US-based customer service staff and moved many customer interactions to AI tools, cutting costs.

P10 International Business Machines Corp. CEO Arvind Krishna said AI could streamline the process of handling contracts with clients, cutting the need for hundreds of staffers to be involved. In August, IBM said it's on pace to reach \$4.5 billion in savings from AI and automation by the end of this year.

P11 In an internal memo earlier this year, Shopify Inc. CEO Tobi Lutke told employees that "teams must demonstrate why they cannot get what they want done using AI" before asking for additional headcount.

P12 Still, it's early days for agents and generative AI. Top AI developers are working to build software that can help automate more work done by research analysts, junior bankers, consultants and software engineers. At the same time, AI companies are trying to provide more clarity on the economic benefits of their tools amid lingering skepticism of the technology's potential to do more than produce unhelpful "workslop."

P13 "There's uncertainty about how useful the tools are and how to fit them into daily work," said Tom Case, a recruiter at Atticus Growth Partners. "They are getting better, but the playbook is still developing."

因此，对人工智能的强调有时可能会产生误导。

这种混乱的动机在亚马逊等大型科技公司身上可以看出。6月，这家电子商务巨头首席执行官安迪·贾西（Andy Jassy）表示，随着人工智能处理更多任务，该公司的员工队伍将在未来几年减少。四个月后，亚马逊宣布将裁员14,000人，贾西表示此举“甚至不是真正的人工智能驱动的，现在不是。”相反，他将其归因于官僚机构更加臃肿。

但最近一系列有关人工智能相关削减的公告确实暗示了该技术的批评者——甚至其布道者——长期以来一直警告过这一现象。在过去的一年里，人工智能已经从聊天机器人进步，这些聊天机器人向所谓的代理人发出聪明的反应，旨在代表用户执行更复杂的任务，无论是进行研究还是编写代码一次数小时。

SPMB的迈克·杜南（Mike Doonan）表示：“人工智能开始承担重复性、大批量的工作。”SPMB招募高级技术和数据领导者。他说，一家大客户解雇了美国客户服务人员，并将许多客户互动转移到人工智能工具上，从而削减了成本。

国际商业机器公司首席执行官Arvind Krishna表示，人工智能可以简化与客户处理合同的过程，减少数百名员工参与的需求。8月，IBM表示，到今年年底，人工智能和自动化方面的节省预计将达到45亿美元。

在今年早些时候的一份内部备忘录中，Shopify Inc. 首席执行官托比·卢特克（Tobi Lutke）告诉员工，“团队必须证明为什么他们无法使用人工智能完成他们想要的事情”，然后才能要求增加员工人数。

尽管如此，对于代理人和生成人工智能来说，现在还处于早期阶段。顶级人工智能开发人员正在努力构建软件，以帮助研究分析师、初级银行家、顾问和软件工程师完成的更多工作自动化。与此同时，人工智能公司正试图更明确地说明其工具的经济效益，因为人们对该技术除了产生无益的“工作污水”的潜力仍持怀疑态度。”

Atticus Growth Partners的招聘人员汤姆·凯斯（Tom Case）表示：“这些工具的有用性如何以及如何将它们融入日常工作中还存在不确定性。”“他们正在变得更好，但剧本仍在发展中。”

P14 If tech firms can ease that uncertainty, it may open the door to wider corporate AI adoption — and more AI-induced cutbacks. Already, Goldman Sachs projects that AI will lead clients to cut headcount by 4% in the next year, with that figure expected to rise to 11% in the next three years.

P15 The investment bank appears poised to join the trend. Last month, Goldman Sachs told employees to expect more job cuts this year as it works to "fully benefit from the promise of AI."

如果科技公司能够缓解这种不确定性，它可能会为更广泛的企业采用人工智能以及更多人工智能引发的削减打开大门。高盛已经预测，人工智能将导致客户在明年裁员4%，预计这一数字将在未来三年内上升至11%。

这家投资银行似乎准备加入这一趋势。上个月，高盛告诉员工，今年将有更多裁员，因为该公司致力于“充分受益于人工智能的承诺”。